

Aged, Blind and Disabled Manual;
Section: Categories of Eligibility;
Policy Manual Number: 115.020;
Chapter: **PICKLE PASSALONG**

Legal Authority: 42 CFR 435.135; Tenn. Comp. R. & Regs. 1200-13-20-.08(3)

1. Overview

The Pickle Passalong Medicaid category is named in honor of U.S. Congressman J.J. Pickle and was established in 1977. To be eligible in the Pickle Passalong category, an individual must have been receiving both Supplemental Security Income (SSI) and Social Security benefits. The individual must have then lost SSI eligibility but would remain SSI-eligible if the Social Security Cost of Living Adjustments (COLAs) received since the SSI payments ended were disregarded.

2. Policy Statement

TennCare Medicaid benefits are available to individuals who would be eligible for SSI payments if increases in Social Security benefits due to COLAs were disregarded. An individual who meets all other non-financial and financial eligibility requirements remains eligible for TennCare Medicaid if he:

- a. Is currently receiving Social Security benefits (Old Age, Survivors, or Disability Insurance (OASDI));
- b. Is not currently receiving SSI;
- c. Was entitled to both OASDI and SSI benefits in the same month after April 1977; and
- d. Has countable income (including in-kind income) equal to or less than the current SSI-Federal Benefit Rate (FBR) after deducting all OASDI COLAs received since the last month in which the individual was eligible for both OASDI and SSI.

3. Non-Financial Eligibility Requirements

a. Age

Individuals must have attained at least age 65 or meet the Social Security Administration (SSA) requirements of blindness or disability. Individuals are not required to provide documentary evidence of age if they are entitled to or enrolled in any part of Medicare.

b. Citizenship

Individuals must be U.S. citizens, U.S. nationals or eligible non-citizens. Individuals are not required to provide documentary evidence of citizenship or national status if they are entitled to or enrolled in any part of Medicare and/or receiving Social Security disability benefits.

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c. Residency

Individuals eligible for this category must be residents of Tennessee.

d. Enumeration

Individuals must possess and provide a valid Social Security Number (SSN) or proof of application for an SSN.

e. Eligible For and Receiving Social Security Benefits

Individuals must be eligible for and receiving Social Security benefits as authorized under Title II of the Social Security Act.

4. Financial Eligibility Requirements

a. Eligibility Determination Group

The Eligibility Determination Group (EDG) is governed by the principle of Financially Responsible Relatives (FRR). Financial responsibility is limited to spouse to spouse and parent to child. See the *ABD Eligibility Determination Group* policy.

b. Couples

Both individuals in a Pickle Passalong eligible couple must meet all Pickle Passalong eligibility criteria to qualify as a Pickle Passalong eligible couple. If an individual's spouse is ineligible for Pickle Passalong, income may be deemed to the individual. See the *ABD Deeming of Income and Resources* policy.

c. Income

i. Income Eligibility

An individual is income eligible if their net countable income less all appropriate Social Security COLAs is less than the appropriate SSI-FBR.

ii. COLA Disregards

Disregard all countable Social Security COLAs that caused or occurred since the applicant's SSI payments ended for the

1. Applicant;
2. Financially responsible spouse; or
3. Other family members.

iii. Determining the Amount of the COLA Disregard

Determine the amount of the COLA disregard by multiplying the applicant's, and if applicable, the applicant's spouse's or other family member's current Social Security benefit by the appropriate conversion factor. Follow the steps below:

1. Verify the individual's current Social Security benefit amount;
2. Verify their SSI non-pay date;
3. Locate the appropriate conversion factor based on the month and year of the SSI non-pay date for the applicant. Use the applicant's conversion factor when calculating the COLA disregard for countable Social Security income received by a spouse or family member;
4. Multiply the current Social Security benefit by the conversion factor; and
5. Take the result (after multiplication by the conversation factor) and deduct it from the current Social Security benefit to determine the COLA disregard amount.

iv. Pickle Conversion Factor Table

Timeframe	Factor	Timeframe	Factor
May-June 1977	0.179	Jan-December 2001	0.534
July 1977-June 1978	0.191	Jan-December 2002	0.548
July 1978-June 1979	0.209	Jan-December 2003	0.555
July 1979-June 1980	0.239	Jan-December 2004	0.567
July 1980-June 1981	0.266	Jan-December 2005	0.582
July 1981-June 1982	0.286	Jan-December 2006	0.607
July 1982-Dec 1983	0.306	Jan-December 2007	0.627
Jan-December 1984	0.316	Jan-December 2008	0.641
Jan-December 1985	0.327	Jan 2009-December 2011	0.678
Jan-December 1986	0.338	Jan-December 2012	0.702
Jan-December 1987	0.342	Jan-December 2013	0.714
Jan-December 1988	0.356	Jan-December 2014	0.725
Jan-December 1989	0.370	Jan 2015-December 2016	0.737
Jan-December 1990	0.388	Jan-December 2017	0.739
Jan-December 1991	0.409	Jan-December 2018	0.755
Jan-December 1992	0.425	Jan-December 2019	0.776
Jan-December 1993	0.437	Jan-December 2020	0.788
Jan-December 1994	0.449	Jan-December 2021	0.799
Jan-December 1995	0.461	Jan-December 2022	0.846
Jan-December 1996	0.473	Jan-December 2023	0.920
Jan-December 1997	0.487	Jan-December 2024	0.949
Jan-December 1998	0.497	Jan-December 2025	0.973
Jan-December 1999	0.503	Jan-December 2026	1.000
Jan-December 2000	0.516		

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d. Resource Limit

Resource limits for this category are \$2,000 for an individual and \$3,000 for a couple.

5. Budget

Mrs. Stone was an SSI and OASDI benefit recipient until October 2013, when her SSI eligibility ended due to an OASDI COLA. She and her husband live together with no children. Mr. Stone is ineligible for SSI or TennCare Medicaid, and \$290 of his OASDI benefits and \$650 of his earned income is deemed available to Mrs. Stone. Mrs. Stone has \$155 in monthly earned income and \$600 in OASDI benefits. She applies for medical assistance on August 1, 2025.

The COLA disregard for Mrs. Stone's Income Budget Calculation will use her SSI non-pay date. This means the October 2013 conversion factor of 0.734 will be used to determine how much can be disregarded from both Mrs. and Mr. Stone's Social Security income. Her COLA disregard is \$159.60, and his COLA disregard is \$77.14, which means Mrs. Stone's total COLA disregard will be \$236.74 in her Income Budget Calculation. Mrs. Stone's net countable income of \$1,003.26 is less than the current SSI-FBR for a household of 2, \$1,450. So, she is income eligible for the Pickle Passalong category.

Income Budget Calculation		
Unearned Income		\$ 600.00
Irregular Unearned Income Disregard	-	\$ 0.00
In-Kind Support and Maintenance	+	\$ 0.00
Ineligible Spouse's Deemed Unearned Income	+	\$ 290.00
Ineligible Parent's Deemed Income	+	\$ 0.00
General Deduction (\$20)	-	\$ 20.00
Child Support Disregard	-	\$ 0.00
Widow/Widower Entitlement Disregard	-	N/A
DAC Entitlement Disregard	-	N/A
COLA Disregard	-	\$ 236.74
Total Net Unearned Income	=	\$ 633.26
Self-Employment Income		\$ 0.00
Earned Income	+	\$ 155.00
Irregular Earned Income Disregard	-	\$ 0.00
Student Earned Income Exclusion	-	\$ 0.00
Ineligible Spouse's Deemed Earned Income	+	\$ 650.00
Remaining General Deduction	-	\$ 0.00
Earned Income Deduction	-	\$ 65.00
Impairment Related Work Expense	-	\$ 0.00
½ Deduction	-	\$ 370.00
Blind Work Expense	-	\$ 0.00
Total Net Earned Income	=	\$ 370.00

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Total Countable Income (Total Net Unearned Income + Total Net Earned Income)	=	\$ 1,003.26
Qualified Income Trust	-	\$ 0.00
Net Countable Income		\$ 1,003.26
Income Test Limit		\$ 1,450.00
Income Test Result		PASS
Patient Liability		N/A

The above budget is current as of October 2025.

Mr. Moore was an SSI and OASDI benefit recipient until December 2021, when his SSI eligibility ended due to an OASDI COLA. He and his wife live together with no children. Mrs. Moore was also an SSI and OASDI benefit recipient until January 2020, when her SSI eligibility ended due to an OASDI COLA. Mr. Moore has \$1,000 in OASDI benefits. Mrs. Moore has \$1,200 in OASDI benefits. Mr. Moore applies for medical assistance on August 1, 2025.

The COLA disregard for Mr. Moore's Income Budget will use his SSI non-pay date. This means the December 2021 conversion factor of 0.821 will be used to determine how much can be disregarded from both Mr. Moore's and Mrs. Moore's Social Security income. His COLA disregard is \$179 and her COLA disregard is \$214.80, which means Mr. Moore's total COLA Disregard will be \$393.80 in his Income Budget Calculation. Mr. Moore's net countable income of \$1,786.20 is greater than the current SSI-FBR for a household of 2, \$1,450. So, he is not income eligible for the Pickle Passalong category.

Income Budget Calculation		
Unearned Income		\$ 2,200.00
Irregular Unearned Income Disregard	-	\$ 0.00
In-Kind Support and Maintenance	+	\$ 0.00
Ineligible Spouse's Deemed Unearned Income	+	\$ 0.00
Ineligible Parent's Deemed Income	+	\$ 0.00
General Deduction (\$20)	-	\$ 20.00
Child Support Disregard	-	\$ 0.00
Widow/Widower Entitlement Disregard	-	N/A
DAC Entitlement Disregard	-	N/A
COLA Disregard	-	\$ 393.80
Total Net Unearned Income	=	\$ 1,786.20
Self-Employment Income		\$ 0.00
Applicant's Earned Income	+	\$ 0.00
Irregular Earned Income Disregard	-	\$ 0.00

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Student Earned Income Exclusion	-	\$ 0.00
Eligible Spouse's and Parent's Deemed Earned Income	+	\$ 0.00
Remaining General Deduction	-	\$ 0.00
Earned Income Deduction	-	\$ 65.00
Impairment Related Work Expense	-	\$ 0.00
½ Deduction	-	\$ 370.00
Blind Work Expense	-	\$ 0.00
Total Net Earned Income	=	\$ 0.00
Total Countable Income (Total Net Unearned Income + Total Net Earned Income)	=	\$ 1,786.20
Qualified Income Trust	-	\$ 0.00
Net Countable Income		\$ 1,786.20
Income Test Limit		\$ 1,450.00
Income Test Result		FAIL
Patient Liability		N/A

The above budget is current as of October 2025.

Note: If the Income Budget Calculation was for Mrs. Moore's eligibility determination, The COLA Disregard would be calculated using her SSI non-pay date, which was January 2020 of 0.810. Her COLA disregard would be \$228 and his COLA disregard would be \$190, which means Mrs. Moore's total COLA Disregard will be \$418 in her Income Budget Calculation.

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Version History

Revision Date	Section	Section Title	Page Number(s)	Reason for Revision	Reviser
3.15.2015				Publication	
03.16.2016	4.c.iii.	Determining the Amount of the COLA Disregard	3	Policy Clarification	LW
03.16.2016	5.b.vi.	COLA Disregard and Eligibility Determination	6	Policy Clarification; Non-Substantive Change	LW
05.02.2016	2.	Policy Statement	1	Policy Clarification	LW
01.05.2017	4.c.iii.	Determining the Amount of the COLA Disregard	3	Policy Clarification	RH
01.05.2017	5.b.vi.	COLA Disregard and Eligibility Determination	6	Policy Clarification	RH
03.09.2018	1.	Overview	1	Policy Change	TN
03.09.2018	2.	Policy Statement	1	Policy Clarification	TN
03.09.2018	4.b.	Couples	2	Policy Clarification	TN
03.09.2018	4.c.iii.	Determining the Amount of the COLA Disregard	3	Policy Clarification	TN
03.09.2018	5.a.6.	Countable Income Computation	5		TN
03.09.2018	5.b.	Example Budget	5 - 6	Non-Substantive Change	TN
03.18.2019	4.a.; 4.c.iii.	Eligibility Determination Group; Determining the Amount of the COLA Disregard	2-3	Policy Clarification	TB
03.18.2019	5.	Budget	3 - 4	Non-Substantive Change	SN
01.02.2020	4.b.iv.; 5.	Legal Authority; Pickle Conversion Factor Table; Budget	1; 3-5	Non-Substantive Change	TN
01.04.2021	4.b.iv.	Pickle Conversion Factor Table	3	Non-Substantive Change	TN
01.04.2022	4.b.iv.	Pickle Conversion Factor Table	3	Non-Substantive Change	SA
01.03.2023	4.b.iv.	Pickle Conversion Factor Table	3	Non-Substantive Change	KF
01.02.2024	4.b.iv.	Pickle Conversion Factor Table	3	Non-Substantive Change	CE
01.02.2025	4.b.iv.	Pickle Conversion Factor Table	3	Non-Substantive Change	CE
08.01.2025	1.; 4.c.ii-iii; 5	Legal Authority; Overview; COLA Disregard; Determining the Amount of the COLA Disregard; Budget	1-6	Policy Clarification	TC
09.25.25	4.c.iii; 5	Determining the Amount of the COLA Disregard; Budget	3; 5-6	Policy Clarification	KJ

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01.05.26	4.c.iv.	Pickle Conversion Factor Table	3	Non-Substantive Change	BP
01.05.26	4.c.iii	Determining the Amount of the COLA Disregard	3	Policy Clarification	BP